

How von der Leyen's people are rising through the ranks

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Presented by Amazon By GERARDO FORTUNA with ZOYA SHEFTALOVICH and GREGORIO SORGI CIAO THERE. It's Gerardo Fortuna, still trapped in Strasbourg at a pl

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CIAO THERE. It's Gerardo Fortuna, still trapped in Strasbourg at a plenary that, frankly, hasn't been the most exciting — as tends to happen when Parliament schedules two in the same month. I picked the wrong one.

In today's Playbook:

- Dubravka Šuica's migration message: More returns, more legal routes into the bloc.
- Strasbourg's hottest new collectibles feature former Parliament presidents.
- Faces in the crowd: Bjoern Seibert, Jozef Síkela, Anthony Whelan, Stéphanie Riso, Stefano Bonaccini, Céline Gauer, Jerzy Buzek, Paulina Dejmek Hack, Maroš Šefčovič, Fernando Andresen Guimaraes and more ...

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya tells Sarah about her personal connection to the Irkutsk Anti-Plague Research Institute of Siberia and the Far East.

****A message from Amazon:** Businesses across Europe are using the AWS Cloud to modernise essential industries. In Valmacca, Italy, xFarm uses cloud technology to help farmers make data-driven decisions, improve productivity, and support more sustainable agricultural practices—connecting farms across Europe and beyond. Hear from more AWS customers across Europe. ******

DRIVING THE DAY

CRACKING THE BERLAYMONT CAREER CODE: How do you get a job running a European Commission department? Do a stint with the president first.

A POLITICO analysis found that 10 of 19 appointments to top jobs in non-technical directorates-general since 2023 went to officials who had worked in Ursula von der Leyen's cabinet, a task force under her

authority or a presidential service. The appointments chart how her circle reaches across the EU executive — and who is in place as she considers clustering or merging departments.

The jump: Paulina Dejmek Hack's rise up the ranks is the latest indication of how von der Leyen and her powerful chief of staff, Bjoern Seibert, run their shop. Dejmek Hack last week landed the job of running the financial services department, after two weeks in post as the department's deputy. She previously served in the Brexit task force in the Secretariat-General, set up to operate "under the direct authority of the President."

Who might be next? Officials close to the Commission's top ranks are watching who rises. One has tipped Fernando Andresen Guimaraes, von der Leyen's former diplomatic adviser and now a director in the fisheries department, as a potential contender for the top job when it comes up for grabs.

That's because it's a pattern. Anthony Whelan, a former member of von der Leyen's cabinet, became director-general at the competition department after a spell as deputy. Kurt Vandenberghe went from her cabinet to run the climate action department. Gert Jan Koopman took over what is now the department for enlargement and the Eastern neighborhood after working on the recovery fund with von der Leyen, Seibert and Stéphanie Riso. Riso became head of the budget department just over a month later.

More receipts: Elisabeth Werner moved from a deputy role in the Secretariat-General to lead the agriculture department. Former chief spokesperson Eric Mamer, who had also run von der Leyen's internal think tank, DG IDEA, became the environment boss a month later. In the summer, Céline Gauer moved from the Secretariat-General to head the energy department. Ditte Juul Jørgensen — who played a leadership role in a transatlantic energy task force set up by von der Leyen — took over on trade. Michael Karnitschnig, a longtime Secretariat-General official overseeing external relations, is acting head of the department for the Middle East and North Africa.

The Commission's reply: Spokesperson Balazs Ujvari said the executive has appointed around 200 senior officials since 2023 and that all selection procedures were merit-based and conducted in strict compliance with the rules. The director-general posts identified by POLITICO were advertised following vacancies, with eligibility and selection criteria published transparently, he said. "The decision to appoint a senior manager is always taken by the College," Ujvari added.

The route: While there is no formal ladder, the officials' paths included experience near the president: in her cabinet, a presidential task force or a Commission service close to her. Several served in deputy posts, gaining the senior-management experience needed to compete for a department's top job. But Ujvari notes it isn't the only route: Candidates for internally advertised director-general jobs can generally qualify from several senior grades, including hors classe adviser, director or principal adviser.

The upshot: Von der Leyen and Seibert have former colleagues running a significant share of the Commission's departments. As the president weighs a restructure of the executive's portfolios, those appointments offer a map of the officials who would have to make any new structure work — and of the professional ties already linking the Berlaymont's top ranks.

BIG AND BREAKING

MEP FACES PARTY PROBE: A Croatian MEP faces an investigation by her national party following a POLITICO report that her friends and family attended a European Parliament event in Strasbourg for

which her office claimed thousands of euros in public money.

CRUNCH TIME IN CHINA: Commission trade chief Maroš Šefčovič is in Beijing for talks with his counterparts that will show whether dialogue with China can actually deliver — with Chinese-made hybrid cars the test case. No deal today or tomorrow would raise the stakes ahead of next week's Council, when leaders will debate whether to keep talking or retaliate. More for subscribers in Morning Trade .

SEE YOU IN SICILY: Ursula von der Leyen, who turns 68 today, is heading to the European People's Party's Study Days in Taormina next week, three officials tell Playbook, with a Monday speech in the works. Then it's back to Brussels for Wednesday's Tripartite Social Summit — and the European Council the day after.

THE REARMAMENT BACKLASH: Europe wants to rearm but the far-right parties surging across the continent have other ideas , seizing on public anger about the cost of living and weakening enthusiasm for higher defense spending.

Meanwhile, in Madrid: Spain's far-right Vox sees the Nov. 29 snap election as a prime opportunity to reshape the political landscape after eight years of Socialist government.

RUBIO'S WARNING: Europe needs to "wake up from its long slumber," U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio said in an address in Athens last night , leaning hard into Donald Trump's "America First" foreign policy with the Acropolis looming behind him.

ŠUICA: AFTER CEUTA

TALKING TOUGH ON MIGRATION: The EU should step up returns of people with no right to stay while opening more legal routes into the bloc, Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica told Playbook's Zoya Sheftalovich from the Med9 summit in Split, a meeting of nine EU countries around the Mediterranean to discuss shared regional issues.

Simple? Speaking days after EU governments approved new rules to boost returns — and amid a push by governments to implement new emergency measures — Šuica said the message is simple: "Those who are illegally in Europe should leave Europe. Those who are in Europe legally can stay."

The how: "We need partner countries," the commissioner said. The EU should invest in the region "to prevent irregular departures," she added, saying "this is the reason why we are signing bilateral partnerships with the countries in North Africa and the Middle East and also in the Gulf."

Not enough: EU leaders are set to discuss ways to respond to migration at next week's European Council, with the shadow of this summer's mass crossing into Ceuta — in which more than 70,000 people entered the Spanish exclave in 48 hours — looming over talks. Greece has called for the temporary suspension of asylum applications in such emergencies, a proposal backed by Germany and Austria.

It's on us: "Protecting our external borders is our European responsibility," Šuica said. The Commission is expected to propose further measures for dealing with emergency migration scenarios after the Council.

****What should be at the top of Europe's agenda? Apply to join the European Pulse Seminar in Brussels this November and have your say on the issues that matter most — from energy and mobility to defense, affordability and technology.****

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

Ambassadors have been discussing a plan that would allow non-EU countries to sign association agreements with the bloc on joining EU defense programs. But what are association agreements? They're formal deals between the EU and another country that allow for closer cooperation in a particular area (in this case, defense) that goes beyond simple cooperation. Signing such an agreement doesn't mean you are joining the EU, but some potential new members do sign them as preparation for one day becoming part of the bloc.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shout-out.

PARLIAMENT'S FIRST BUDGET WIN

DEAL ON DEVELOPMENT CASH: The European Parliament is expected to seal a deal today on the first major plank of the EU's next seven-year budget. MEPs are set to agree among themselves the rules governing €200 billion in development funds, three officials involved in the negotiations told Gregorio Sorigi.

Today's agreement on the Global Europe fund — which is due to be confirmed by a committee vote on Oct. 19 — comes amid divisions in Parliament over agriculture, green rules and Buy European, which threaten to delay the negotiations with member countries.

Tit for tat? Parliament's two largest groups — the European People's Party and the Socialists and Democrats — had to overcome disagreement over whether to cut development aid for countries that fail to readmit migrants that crossed into Europe.

The final compromise allows the Commission to cut financial assistance under certain circumstances, but safeguards funding for civil society and human rights groups. In another compromise, MEPs dropped references to "innovative solutions," which was seen as code for using EU cash to build migrant return hubs abroad.

The Gaza question: Groups were also split over whether to earmark Brussels funds for the reconstruction of Gaza. MEPs mentioned that the EU should play a role in this process but, in a concession to the EPP, they dropped any figures.

DASHBOARD

The Brussels-Capital Region's population stagnated in 2025 after "30 years of uninterrupted growth," the Brussels Institute for Statistics and Analysis said Wednesday. Moves from abroad "remain the factor that contributes the most to population growth in the region," but more people left Brussels to move to other regions in Belgium than arrived, according to the institute.

5 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

ARCTIC AMBITIONS: International Partnerships Commissioner Jozef Síkela is in Reykjavík for the Arctic Circle Assembly — the final stop on his tour of the region and one last chance to shape the debate before the College adopts its new Arctic strategy in two weeks. He'll sketch out priorities including serving Arctic communities, strengthening the "Northern Neighbourhood," boosting security and resilience, increasing investment and accelerating the fight against climate change.

PRESSED TO PULL OUT: The Trump administration pressured EU, Canadian and Lithuanian diplomats to withdraw from a disinformation conference over panels that warned against American influence, my colleagues scooped .

LOOK WHO'S COMING TO DINNER: The U.K. will take part in an EU Foreign Affairs Council on development for the first time since Brexit, with Development Minister Kirsty McNeill representing London at the official dinner in Dublin this evening after meeting her Irish counterpart Neale Richmond.

MAYORS SAY NO: Twenty mayors from big EU cities including Brussels, Rome, Paris and Madrid have come out against EU budget cuts in a letter seen by Playbook, signed with the President of the European Committee of the Regions Kata Tüttö.

BEEN HERE BEFORE: The EU's top auditor, Tony Murphy, has warned that the bloc's next seven-year budget risks suffering from the same "mistakes" that have plagued its €575 billion post-Covid fund. More in Morning Financial Services (for subscribers).

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Cooler with a few showers. High of 16C.

DOING THE ROUNDS IN PARLIAMENT: S&D heavyweight Stefano Bonaccini could return to national politics and run in next year's Italian election, according to three Parliament officials. Green Andrea Zannoni would be the next cab off the rank to take his European seat.

Firewall fight: The European Parliament defended itself in court against claims by the Patriots for Europe group that it helped centrist political forces keep the far right out of top jobs in committees.

Piling on: The Brussels bubble woke up Wednesday to three EPP lawmakers moving to reject the Industrial Accelerator Act — while Parliament's software was literally buckling under a whopping 5,300 amendments. The rebellion has since grown to 24. More in Morning Fair Play (for subscribers).

THE NEW COLLECTIBLE: Bookmarks featuring former European Parliament presidents are taking over the building in Strasbourg, scattered around the corridors ... and people have started collecting them. (Your author has already received several requests to bring some back to Brussels.)

Gotta catch 'em all: Roberta Metsola and the late David Sassoli are still relatively easy to find. Antonio Tajani is trickier, though Playbook spotted one in the wild; and there are people who swear they've seen a Martin Schulz.

Oh, it goes deeper: Playbook learned that the Parliament Library has been printing them since 2024 to promote its services. The collection stretches back to Jerzy Buzek and even Hans-Gert Pöttering — finding one of those would be like finding a Golden Ticket in a Wonka chocolate bar. A Parliament

spokesperson said the bookmarks were there to remind people that they can subscribe to the EP Library.

If you say so: We see a future collectibles market in all this. On that note, anyone with a spare Buzek: Your author is offering a duplicate Sassoli. Serious offers only.

BERLAYMONT ART EXHIBIT: Spend enough time at the European Commission's HQ and you'll notice a rather risqué art exhibition outside the canteen. Ukrainian-born Belgian artist Andrej Babenko's work (which includes a painting seemingly depicting a woman giving oral sex) is for sale, with one piece going for €14,000. One passing official wondered whether that space was even supposed to be commercialized ...

SPOTTED ... at the evening reception in Strasbourg of the European Beer Group (one of the Parliament's oldest cross-party groups, bringing together MEPs interested in Europe's brewing sector since 1995): group Co-Chairs Tomáš Zdechovský and Hannes Heide; MEPs Benoît Cassart, Michał Szczerba, Stefano Cavedagna, Tomislav Sokol and Maravillas Abadía Jover; Julia Leferman, Simon Spillane and Jozef Pres from The Brewers of Europe; consultants Alessandro Cinciripini and Martina Mazzeo; your Playbook author Gerardo Fortuna, happy to report that nothing bridges political divides quite like a beer.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz now faces a possible split among CDU lawmakers in Saxony-Anhalt as the fallout over the AfD vote deepens.

Paris: PM Sébastien Lecornu saved his big announcement in last night's speech for tackling rising fuel prices, leaving students to return to the streets today without fresh answers.

London: Andy Burnham is heading to Berlin to meet Friedrich Merz , with Russia's hybrid threats high on the agenda.

Washington: Democrats are bullish about taking back the House and maybe even the Senate next month — and polls suggest they'll have Donald Trump to thank.

Ottawa: Mark Carney heads to Quebec with a peace offering for incoming Premier Paul St-Pierre Plamondon: new measures for "clean, affordable and reliable energy."

Canberra: Pillar 2 of AUKUS — which goes beyond nuclear-powered submarines — is floundering, forcing officials to consider drastically narrowing the scope of the project .

** As defense leaders gather in Warsaw, follow the priorities shaping European security with POLITICO Pro's Defense newsletter. Sign up for a trial of Pro Morning defense here. **

AGENDA

— Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič is in Beijing for trade talks with his Chinese counterparts Wang Wentao and He Lifeng.

— European Council President António Costa meets EEAS Secretary-General Kajsa Ollongren at 10:30 a.m. and ASEAN ambassadors at 12:15 p.m.

- European Parliament President Roberta Metsola presides over the Conference of Presidents at 10 a.m. during Parliament’s plenary session in Strasbourg.
- The Eurogroup meets in Luxembourg at 3 p.m. Press conference at 7 p.m. Watch live .
- International Partnerships Commissioner Jozef Síkela will give a speech at the Arctic Circle Assembly in Reykjavík, Iceland, on “the European Union in the Arctic” at 3:45 p.m. Watch live .
- Enlargement Commissioner Marta Kos speaks at an international conference on Corridor VIII in Sofia, Bulgaria, and meets Bulgaria’s Foreign Affairs Minister Velislava Petrova-Chamova.
- EU High Representative Kaja Kallas continues her visit to Lebanon.
- Rule of Law Commissioner Michael McGrath meets Albanian Prime Minister Edi Rama in Tirana.
- Sustainable Transport Commissioner Apostolos Tzitzikostas meets Maltese Prime Minister Robert Abela in Valletta.
- German Chancellor Friedrich Merz receives U.K. Prime Minister Andy Burnham in Berlin.
- NATO Deputy Secretary-General Radmila Shekerinska begins a two-day visit to Chişinău, Moldova.
- Commission Executive Vice President Teresa Ribera gives a keynote speech on Spain’s 40 years of EU integration at the Ramón Rubial Foundation in Bilbao, Spain, at 7:30 p.m. Watch live .
- Environment Commissioner Jessika Roswall receives European Metals President Inge Hofkens.

BIRTHDAYS

European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen; former MEPs Bas Eickhout, Ivo Hristov, Stéphane Bijoux and Czesław Siekierski; London Mayor Sadiq Khan; BK Partners’ Frédéric Vincent; Euros/Agency’s Mathieu Collet; Zoran Zaev, former prime minister of North Macedonia; Left Group’s Sonja Giese.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO’s EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere, Sebastian Starcevic and Gregorio Sorgi. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

******A message from Amazon: Founded to support the digital evolution of farming, xFarm uses the AWS Cloud to power a platform that helps farmers improve productivity while keeping sustainability at the core of their operations. By turning agricultural data into actionable insights, xFarm enables farmers to make smarter decisions in an increasingly complex environmental and economic landscape. “With the AWS Cloud, we can connect farms around the world, transforming agriculture through innovation while keeping sustainability at the heart of everything we do,” says Giovanni Causapruno of xFarm. xFarm is one of many European businesses building on the AWS Cloud to operate at scale, strengthen resilience, and support more sustainable food systems. The AWS Cloud helps xFarm extend its impact across borders—supporting farmers as they adapt to today’s environmental and operational challenges. Learn more about how businesses across Europe are growing with the AWS Cloud at [AWS.eu](https://aws.eu). ******

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